

Gatha :

Experience Art Beyond the Frame

WHAT IT IS

A VR learning experience that explores Indian art through context, interaction, and participation not just labels.

Gatha allows museum visitors to step into the world surrounding an Indian art form, discover its history and making process, and apply what they learn through an interactive creation experience.



HOW IT STARTED

Observation

The project began during a visit to art and culture museums in Delhi, where I noticed a gap between visitors' curiosity around traditional Indian art and the way contextual information was presented. While artworks sparked interest in their stories, origins, materials, and making processes, the experience largely relied on short exhibit labels. In contrast, interactive installations, such as holographic displays and action-based exhibits, attracted more visitor participation. This raised an initial question around whether interaction could help visitors explore the context behind an artwork without interrupting the museum experience.



HOW MIGHT WE

Problem Identification

The gap was not a lack of information, but how visitors engaged with it. The history, cultural context, and making processes behind traditional Indian art were difficult to explore through short exhibit descriptions, creating an opportunity for a more participatory learning experience.

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How might we enhance the learning experience around Indian art during a museum visit?

— DESIGN QUESTION

HOW IT IS GOING

Research

To validate the initial observation, I used a mix of contextual inquiry, visitor conversations, and secondary research to understand how people engage with museum information and interactive exhibits.

40 Visitors engaged

Informal conversations around their museum experience

2 Modes Observed

Static exhibits vs. interactive installations

Global + India Experience scan

Museum, immersive and experiential exhibition formats

Multiple formats Compared

Labels · Digital guides · Interactive displays · Immersive exhibitions · Spatial experiences

What I looked for ?

1. Visitor Behavior

How people approached, explored, and moved between exhibits

2. Information Behavior

What happened when visitors wanted to know more

3. Interaction Behavior

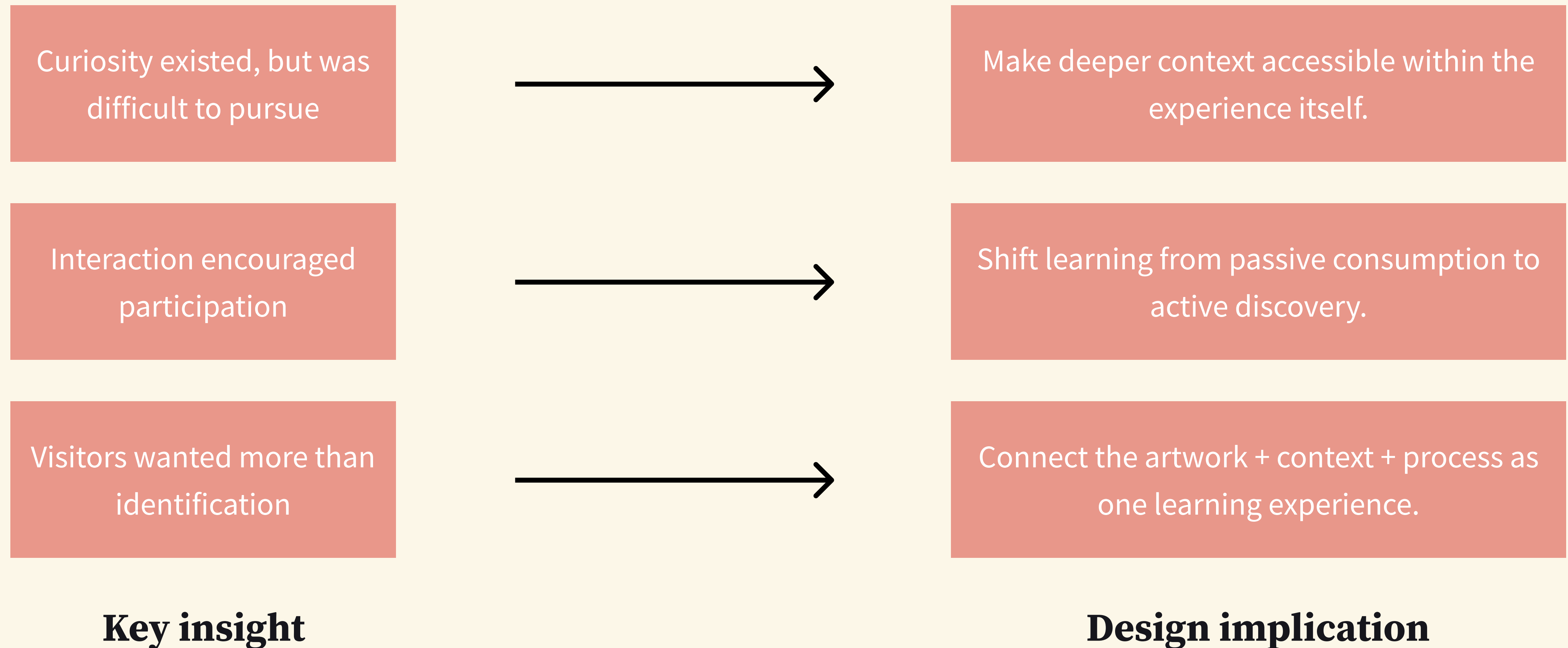
How behavior differed around static vs. interactive exhibits

4. Existing Experiences

How museums and exhibitions use interaction, immersion, and spatial storytelling

WHAT I FOUND

The research was synthesized into three recurring patterns that shaped the direction of the experience.



WHAT I THOUGHT

With the opportunity defined, I explored how learning could become part of the museum experience itself, rather than adding another layer of information through an app or website. The concepts were evaluated against three requirements derived from research: keep visitors within the experience, encourage active participation, and communicate the story and making of Indian art forms.

Why VR?

VR offered a way to combine spatial storytelling, interaction, exploration, and hands-on making within one experience. Instead of becoming another information layer beside the artwork, it could become an interactive exhibit within the museum itself.

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Searching for additional information could pull visitors away from the museum experience.

— RESEARCH FINDING

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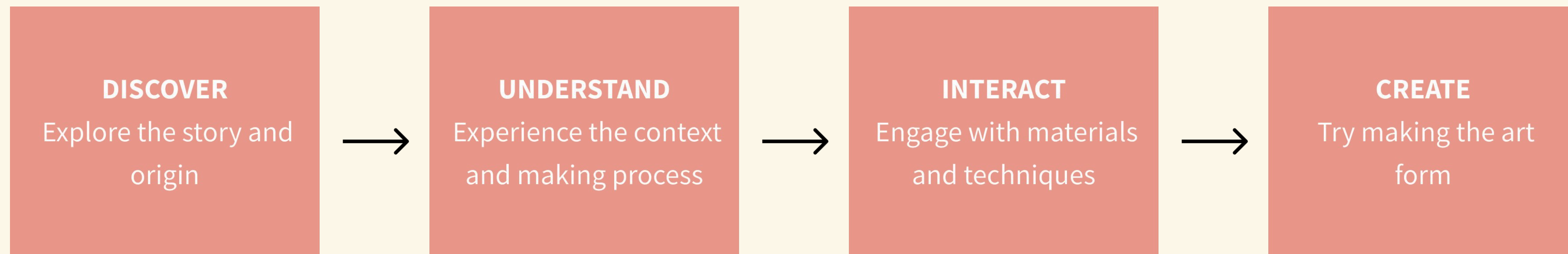
Interactive installations showed greater visible participation because visitors had something to do rather than only something to read.

— RESEARCH FINDING

The medium shifted from designing information for visitors to designing an experience they could participate in.

HOW I MADE IT

The medium shifted from designing information for visitors to designing an experience they could participate in.



This direction became Gatha, with the prototype focusing on traditional Indian art forms such as Kalamkari, Madhubani, Warli and Pichwai.

Core Concept

Instead of placing Indian art inside a virtual museum, Gatha places the visitor inside the world behind the art.

WHAT I DESIGNED

Making Gaatha

Once VR was established as the medium, the focus shifted from defining what the solution should be to designing how the experience should unfold in space. I developed Gatha progressively from understanding the content of each art form, to mapping the experience, storyboarding key moments, defining spatial interactions, and finally translating them into a high-fidelity prototype.



Defining the Content

I studied Indian artforms like Kalamkari, Madhubani, Warli, and Pichwai across four layers:

Origin • Context • Process • Making

SECTION NAME

Experience Architecture

The experience was structured around a simple progression:

SELECT → ENTER → EXPLORE → INTERACT → MAKE

Storyboarding

I mapped the experience frame-by-frame before designing the interface, defining what users would see, discover, and do at each stage.

Spatial Interaction

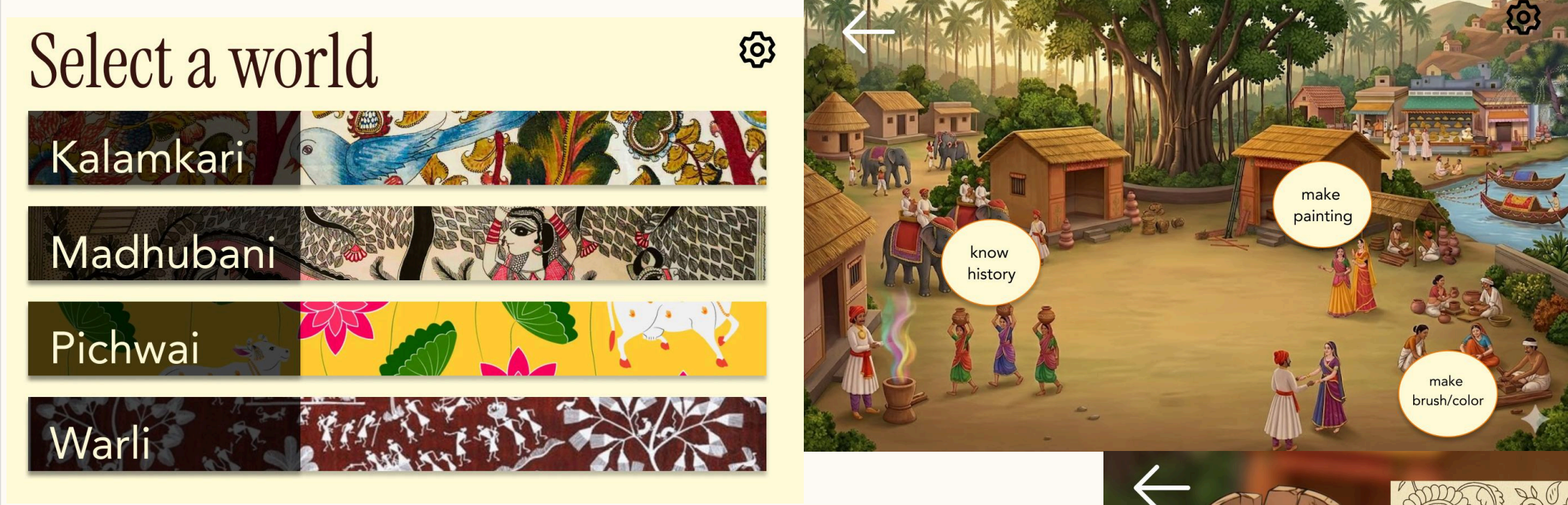
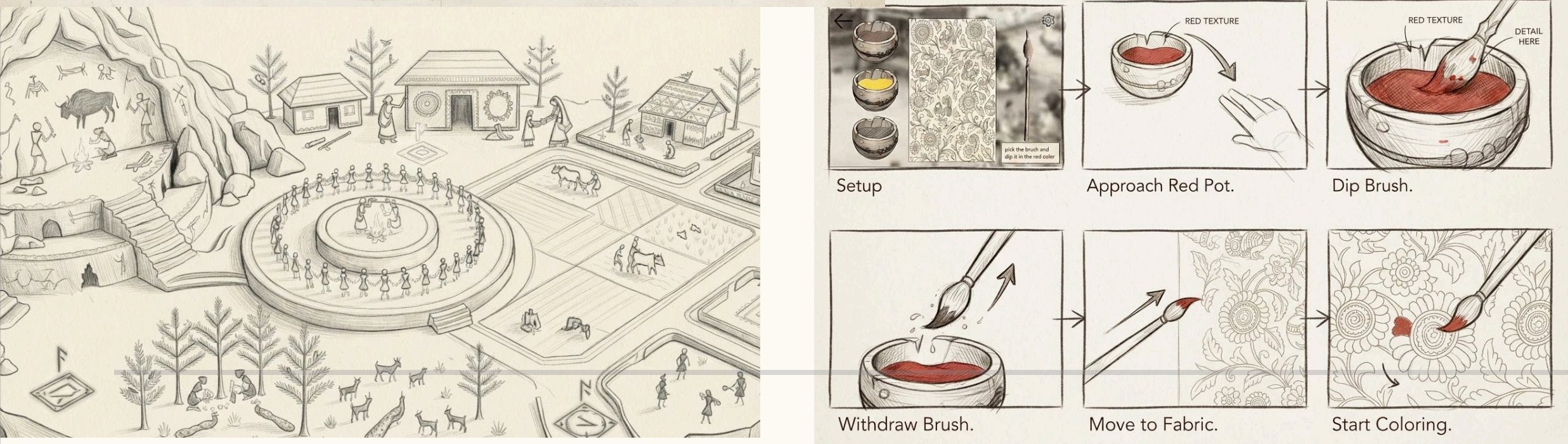
The storyboard was translated into VR interactions by defining where information lives and how users interact with it.

World Lock • Body Lock • Ray Cast • Touch • Pinch • Object Manipulation

SECTION NAME

From Lo-Fi to Hi-Fi

Early spatial frames were iterated into the final experience, refining information placement, interaction states, feedback, and environmental cues.



Gaatha — An Immersive Learning Experience for Indian Art

Gaatha is a museum-based VR experience that enables visitors to explore traditional Indian art forms beyond the finished artwork. Each art form is translated into an interactive cultural environment, bringing together its history, context, materials, and making process within one experience. Users can choose what they want to explore and move from learning about the art to actively participating in its creation.

SCREENS



FEATURE 3



